Route parameters are sections of a URL that may vary but are still a match for the template. You define them by giving them a name and placing them in braces, such as `{category}` or `{name}`. When used in this way, the parameters are required, so the request URL must have a segment that they correspond to, but the value can vary.

The ability to use route parameters gives you great flexibility. The simple route template `"/{category}/{name}"` could be used to match all the product-page URLs in an e-commerce application:

- `/bags/rucksack-a`—Where `category=bags` and `name=rucksack-a`
- `/shoes/black-size9`—Where `category=shoes` and `name=black-size9`

But note that this template would *not* map the following URLs:

- `/socks/`—No `name` parameter specified
- `/trousers/mens/formal`—Extra URL segment, `formal`, not found in route template

When a route template defines a route parameter and the route matches a URL, the value associated with the parameter is captured and stored in a dictionary of values associated with the request. These *route values* typically drive other behavior in the endpoint and can be injected into the handlers (as you saw briefly in chapter 5) in a process called *model binding*.

DEFINITION *Route values* are the values extracted from a URL based on a given route template. Each route parameter in a template has an associated route value, and the values are stored as a string pair in a dictionary. They can be used during model binding, as you'll see in chapter 7.